

SXST-3010: Critical Histories & Contemporary Perspectives on Human Sexuality

Term: Fall Term

Instructor: Dr. Evelyn Vance

Format: Seminar / Lecture

Credits: 4.0 Units

1. COURSE OVERVIEW & THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This course investigates sexuality not as an innate biological constant, but as a historically contingent, discursive, and institutional formation. Tracing developments across clinical sexology, psychiatric categorizations, and legal codifications, students will analyze how power operates through norms of gender, bodily autonomy, race, and relationality. We examine foundational theoretical interventions that challenge compulsory binaries and explore alternative modalities of care, kinship, and digital intimacy.

Curricular Structure Note: This course decouples thematic research modules from weekly seminar readings. Weekly readings establish the chronological historiography (Weeks 1–10), whereas thematic modules (Modules 1–10) supply theoretical paradigms for term research papers.

2. WEEKLY COURSE READINGS (WEEKS 1 – 4)

Week 1: The Emergence of Modern Western Sexology

Reading 1: Havelock Ellis, Studies in the Psychology of Sex, Volume II: Sexual Inversion (1915), Ch. 1 & 4 (pp. 1–45).

Examines late-Victorian taxonomy, congenital inversion arguments, and forensic medicine's secularization of bodily desire from sin to medical anomaly.

Week 2: The Repressive Hypothesis and Discursive Production

Reading 2: Michel Foucault, The History of Sexuality, Volume 1: An Introduction (1978), Part Two: "The Repressive Hypothesis", Ch. 1–2 (pp. 17–49).

Interrogates whether Victorian culture repressed sexual discourse or proliferated forensic speech; introduces biopower and the confessional apparatus.

Week 3: Stratification and the Limits of Tolerance

Reading 3: Gayle Rubin, "Thinking Sex: Notes for a Radical Theory of the Politics of Sexuality" (1984), Section: "The Charmed Circle" (pp. 267–319).

Articulates the hierarchical pyramid of sexual value, state-sanctioned legitimacy, and the necessity of separating gender theory from sexuality theory.

Week 4: Transgender Genealogies and Bodily Autonomy

Reading 4: Susan Stryker, Transgender History (2008), Chapter 2: "A Hundred Years of Transgender History" (pp. 45–90).

Traces mid-20th-century street resistance, medical gatekeeping, the Compton's Cafeteria Riot, and transgender community self-determination.

2. WEEKLY COURSE READINGS (WEEKS 5 – 10, CONTINUED)

Week 5: Intersectional Erotics and Racialized Subjectivities

Reading 5: Audre Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power", in *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* (1984), pp. 53–59.

Deconstructs pornographic reductionism; frames the erotic as an embodied, non-rational source of internal political and ethical power.

Week 6: Compulsory Normativity and Institutional Erasure

Reading 6: Adrienne Rich, "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence", *Signs*, Vol. 5, No. 4 (1980), pp. 631–660.

Investigates heterosexuality as an enforced social and economic imperative rather than spontaneous preference; defines the lesbian continuum.

Week 7: Subcultural Geographies and Non-Linear Temporalities

Reading 7: Jack Halberstam, *In a Queer Time and Place: Transgender Bodies, Subcultural Lives* (2005), Ch. 1: "Queer Temporality and Postmodernism" (pp. 1–21).

Critiques bourgeois reproductive timelines (birth, marriage, inheritance) through alternative rhythms of subcultural survival.

Week 8: Chosen Kinship and Mutual Aid Formations

Reading 8: Kath Weston, *Families We Choose: Lesbians, Gays, Kinship* (1991), Ch. 4: "Exiles from Kinship" (pp. 103–136).

Analyzes the dialectic between biological exile and chosen relational structures forged during crises of social exclusion.

Week 9: Platformized Desire and Algorithmic Surveillance

Reading 9: Susanna Paasonen, *Carnal Resonance: Affect and Online Pornography* (2011), Ch. 3: "Distraction, Affect, and Flows" (pp. 77–112).

Explores somatic audience responses, interface designs, content moderation filters, and digital economies of arousal.

Week 10: Cripistemologies and Accessible Intimacies

Reading 10: Robert McRuer, *Crip Theory: Cultural Signs of Queerness and Disability* (2006), Ch. 1: "Compulsory Able-Bodiedness" (pp. 1–32).

Analyzes the co-constitution of ableist productivity norms and heteronormative sexual desirability.

3. THEMATIC RESEARCH MODULES (MODULES 1 – 4)

Modules represent cross-cutting research units decoupled from the weekly calendar.

MODULE 01

Medicalization & Diagnostic Power

Historiographical inquiry into DSM pathology revisions, conversion therapy bans, and psychiatric authority.

MODULE 02

Biopolitics & State Regulation

Explores state surveillance, anti-sodomy laws, anti-cross-dressing statutes, and municipal panopticons.

MODULE 03

Geographies of Counter-Culture

Spatial analysis of gay enclaves, cruising grounds, bathhouses, and subcultural safe harbors.

MODULE 04

Activism, Direct Action & Law

From post-war homophile leagues and Stonewall to ACT UP direct action and contemporary litigation.

3. THEMATIC RESEARCH MODULES (MODULES 5 – 10, CONTINUED)

MODULE 05 Black Queer Studies & Decoloniality Racialized sexualities, colonial epistemic violence, and global intersectional critique.	MODULE 06 The Feminist Sex Wars & Agency The 1980s Barnard Conference debates, anti-pornography censorship vs. sex-positive agency.
MODULE 07 Indigenous & Transnational Paradigms Two-Spirit epistemologies, Hijra legal recognitions, and non-Western gender pluralisms.	MODULE 08 Epidemiology, Stigma & Public Health HIV/AIDS activism, blood bans, PrEP access politics, and biomedical moral policing.
MODULE 09 Camp Aesthetics & Media Tropes Hays Code censorship, queer coding in classical Hollywood, zines, and ballroom culture.	MODULE 10 Technoculture & Synthetic Desires Algorithmic moderation, tele-intimacy, synthetic media, and post-human relationality.

4. ASSESSMENT & ASSIGNMENT MATRIX (ASSIGNMENTS 1 – 10)

All deliverables must be submitted via the institutional portal by 11:59 PM on the designated date.

Assessment	Due Date	Weight	Deliverable Description & Evaluation Focus
Assignment 1: Précis	Week 2 (Fri)	5%	500-word critical précis analyzing Havelock Ellis or Foucault's central theoretical claim.
Assignment 2: Archival Analysis	Week 3 (Fri)	10%	Close-reading of a 19th-century medical or penal artifact interpreted via Rubin's "Charmed Circle".
Assignment 3: Trans History Study	Week 4 (Sun)	10%	1,200-word case study documenting mid-20th-century street resistance and mutual aid.
Assignment 4: Midterm Essay	Week 5 (Fri)	15%	Comparative paper putting Lorde's erotic power into dialogue with institutional discipline.
Assignment 5: Research Proposal	Week 6 (Wed)	5%	1-page thesis prospectus identifying selected thematic research module and primary sources.
Assignment 6: Peer Review Draft	Week 7 (Thu)	5%	1,500-word rough draft circulated for double-blind peer workshop and methodological critique.
Assignment 7: Kinship Mapping	Week 8 (Fri)	10%	Analytical diagram and report evaluating Weston's chosen family structures vs. legal kinship.
Assignment 8: Platform Critique	Week 9 (Fri)	10%	1,000-word technical analysis of algorithmic shadowbanning and sexual content moderation.
Assignment 9: Accessibility Audit	Week 10 (Fri)	10%	Application of McRuer's crip theory to evaluate an educational or healthcare delivery environment.
Assignment 10: Capstone Essay	Exam Week (Dec 14)	20%	3,500-word research essay synthesizing two thematic modules with archival and theoretical evidence.